

I am sorry

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As I flip through old photos and albums, I see my sister and me holding hands—her small hand gently clasping mine. She’s two years older, noticeably taller. I can almost feel her quiet sense of responsibility as an older sister, as if she’s holding my hand just a little tighter than I’m holding hers. Our faces are round and chubby, expressions innocent, completely unaware of anything beyond the simplicity of that moment. I smile softly as I turn the pages, studying our expressions and trying to imagine what was happening in those moments frozen in time.

I try to piece together the stories my parents have told me. My sister used to chase me around, calling me by my nickname, “Doong-i,” and say “Saranghae”—“I love you” in Korean—more than she said it to my parents. This surprised them, as they thought she would be jealous of a younger sibling getting more of their attention, as other children often are. Matching what they’ve told me, I can see her affection for me in her eyes shining through the dry paper. But when I reach the final page and close the album, a sense of emptiness washes over me. Staring at the dusty back cover, I let myself return to the present, and the reality of now feels distant. In that quiet space, I picture my 21-year-old sister with autism, softly murmuring to herself as she works on her coloring book.

We aren’t close anymore—not like we used to be. We no longer hold hands, no longer share that bond. I long for a time I wouldn’t have known existed until I saw it in those pictures. While I don’t have a clear sense of how I felt having my sister then, the sense of loss stirred something deep within me. I wondered if she still loves me the way she did when we were kids. When I look into her eyes, there’s something pure in them, something unchanged. And her innocent expression somehow fills me with guilt.

I’m a guilty sibling. I stole light from her. I excelled in school and basked in the praise that came with it. When my parents came home from work, I was happy to see their tired faces light up as I handed them my transcript for the quarter. They were proud, but they never explicitly set expectations for me. I set them for myself—telling myself I had to do better on behalf of my sister. I was proud and happy to be a good child, and being a good child made me want to be a better child. This self-feeding cycle of achievement and pride took me a long time to recognize ableism I internalized. Growing up in a community where academic achievement was highly praised, my sister remained as a shadow when I got the spotlight.

This realization hit me hard when I got into Princeton. I remember the moment when my parents said, “We’re so proud of you, for all your hard work. I used to feel small because of your sister, but because of you, I can stand proud.” I was proud of my achievements, but those words from my parents made me uncomfortable. I didn’t want to face the ableism embedded in their praise. In their eyes, my success was a victory not just for me, but for them too. They had finally “won,” in a way they couldn’t through my sister.

Hearing their ableism speak directly to me, I became deeply concerned. Through their lens, I saw my own ableism—something I had avoided confronting for so long—and I started questioning it. Was I shining so brightly because her achievements were never valued? Did I take value away from her and reinforce ableism in our family by not challenging the standards that society holds over us? Was my intention for achievement just?

The more I thought about it, the more I realized how much I had internalized ableist beliefs. I had been raised in a system that equated worth with success, with achievements, with doing things “right”—things that my sister, in her own way, could not always meet in the same way society expected. I didn’t challenge these standards; instead, I embraced them and used them to define myself. But in doing so, I failed to see my sister’s worth, her unique form of achievement, her quiet strength.

If my achievements isolate my sister and reinforce ableism, I know I have a responsibility. Ableism within the family—especially with a family member who has disabilities—hits harder. It broke the bond I once had with my sister when I was unaware of her disabilities. It is I who abandoned our bond, justifying it by telling myself I had to do more, achieve more, to make up for what I perceived as her inability to do the same. But in doing so, I further isolated her, further distanced myself from the sister I once held so close. While I embraced the inflexible standard of success and societal expectations that my sister could not meet, I had subtly devalued her work—her paintings, her writing, her progress through various therapies, and her medals from the Special Olympics. I did not acknowledge the effort and meaning behind them, as she tried, in her own way, to realize herself.

Recognizing how long my sister had been dealing with the ableism within our family, I became desperate to make up for my past mistakes. I started paying closer attention to her, searching for any remaining connection that might bridge the gap between us. As I looked at her with a new perspective, I felt an even deeper sense of guilt as I recognized her deep affection and desire to connect with me. She still calls me by the nickname “Doong-i,” and still draws pictures of our family, carefully labeling each one with our names. While it took me far too long to realize that the true value of family lies in embracing one another and showing affection, my sister had always understood these values.

I know I can’t undo the years of prioritizing my own accomplishments over her feelings. I can’t go back and change the way I was raised in a system that taught me to measure worth through external successes. But I can start by confronting this ableism within myself that I was not able to fully correct. I want to rebuild the bond I had with my sister long ago—that is clearly reflected in the brief glimpses of our childhood. I want to hold her hand and let her hold mine tighter, matching her eyes full of love for her younger sister. I can’t undo the past, but I must confront it. And I have to say the words I’ve held back for so long. I am sorry.